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From creative output to creative governance: Legitimizing AI-generated creativity under deepfake uncertainty

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ABSTRACT

Generative artificial intelligence challenges established foundations of innovation legitimacy by decoupling output quality from human effort, intention, and responsibility. When creative outputs no longer provide reliable signals of human agency, legitimacy judgments must be reconstructed through alternative interpretive cues. This study reconceptualizes innovation legitimacy as an inferential process formed under conditions of technological opacity and examines how governance practices shape legitimacy judgments in AI-mediated creativity.

Drawing on a survey-based experiment (N = 240), we investigate how configurations of AI involvement, transparency timing, and deepfake-related manipulation cues influence perceived deception, perceived human effort, and perceived authenticity. Legitimacy judgments, operationalized as inferential assessments of deception, effort, and authenticity, are distinguished from their downstream attitudinal and behavioral consequences. The findings show that legitimacy in AI-mediated creativity shifts from output-based evaluation toward governance-dependent sensemaking. Transparency operates as an interpretive mechanism whose effects depend critically on timing, while deepfake cues systematically heighten moral uncertainty and undermine legitimacy.

By specifying the microfoundations through which legitimacy breaks down and is partially reconstructed under AI-induced opacity, the study advances innovation theory by reframing legitimacy as a governance-dependent inferential achievement. This reframing differs from existing interpretive and institutional accounts: governance is conceptualized not as a mechanism that generates legitimacy directly through compliance or ceremonial conformity, but as an interpretive infrastructure that shapes the conditions under which audiences can form legitimacy judgments when conventional output-based cues are absent. The findings contribute to debates on AI governance, innovation diffusion, and responsible innovation in contexts characterized by ambiguous agency and uncertainty about algorithmic production processes.

1. Introduction

Over the past decade, generative Artificial Intelligence (gen-AI) has become increasingly integrated into creative production. AI-generated texts, images, videos, and synthetic voices now frequently achieve levels of quality comparable to those produced by humans. This development challenges established assumptions about how creativity, human effort, and innovation are evaluated. A central feature of this shift is the weakening of the connection between creative outputs and the human effort, intention, and responsibility traditionally associated with their production. In most creative fields, qualities such as originality and craftsmanship enabled audiences to reconstruct how an artifact was produced and by whom. Gen-AI undermines this logic. The same output quality can now result from very different levels of human involvement. This loss of inferential cues challenges established theories of innovation legitimacy. Legitimacy has not been grounded solely in performance or aesthetic value, but in the perceived alignment between outcomes and human intention, authorship, and accountability. When this alignment cannot be inferred from the output, innovation may perform effectively while failing to sustain legitimacy. These dynamics are especially apparent in the context of highly realistic synthetic media and deepfakes. Here, audiences struggle to distinguish authentic content

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from manipulated content and to infer whether creative artifacts originate from human expression or algorithmic processes. As a result, evaluative attention moves away from the artifact and toward how creative production is organized and governed, a shift that remains only partially theorized in the innovation literature.

Prior studies predominantly focus on how audiences evaluate the quality, creativity, or acceptance of AI-generated content, often comparing human and machine outputs or examining attitudinal responses to disclosure (e.g., Hong and Curran, 2019; Tigre Moura et al., 2023; Magni et al., 2024). Within this stream, transparency and disclosure are typically treated as instrumental mechanisms designed to enhance trust, reduce uncertainty, or improve user attitudes toward AI-generated artifacts (Ananny and Crawford, 2018; Glikson and Woolley, 2020). While these prior studies offer important insights into audience responses to AI-generated content, they leave largely unexplored how legitimacy judgments are formed when outputs no longer provide information about human agency and responsibility. As a result, a critical theoretical issue remains insufficiently addressed: *How are legitimacy judgments formed when creative outputs are produced through generative AI, and how do governance practices shape the inferential processes and their outcomes through which audiences reconstruct meaning under conditions of technological opacity?*

This study reconceptualizes innovation legitimacy as an inferential judgment formed under conditions of uncertainty. When Gen-AI severs the link between outputs and human agency, the basis upon which legitimacy judgments are formed shifts from performance to the governance of creative processes (Joosten et al., 2024; Badawy, 2025). Building on this perspective, legitimacy in AI-mediated creativity shifts from creative output to creative governance (Bitektine and Haack, 2015; Haack et al., 2021). Governance practices such as the disclosure of AI involvement, the timing of transparency, and assurances of human oversight provide audiences with interpretive cues through which authenticity, effort, and moral appropriateness are inferred (Ananny and Crawford, 2018; Heimstädt and Dobusch, 2020). These practices do not generate legitimacy directly but shape the conditions under which legitimacy judgments can be formed when creative processes are technologically opaque (Grimmelikhuijsen and Meijer, 2022; König and Wenzelburger, 2021; Park, 2026).

The empirical context focuses on AI-mediated organizational communication, specifically on how audiences evaluate creative messages produced and disseminated by organizations through digital and social media channels. While the theoretical framework applies more broadly to AI-driven innovation, the experimental stimuli and measures are designed to capture legitimacy judgments in communicative contexts where organizational identity, creative agency, and governance practices are simultaneously at stake. Using a survey-based experiment, it analyzes how variations in the role of AI in creation, the timing of transparency, and the presence of deepfake-like manipulation cues shape inferential mechanisms such as perceived deception, perceived human effort, and perceived authenticity. It then examines how these mechanisms relate to attitudes toward the message and the organization, as well as behavioral intentions.

The paper makes three contributions to research on innovation legitimacy and AI governance. First, it demonstrates that under conditions of AI-induced opacity, legitimacy judgments shift from output-based evaluation toward governance-dependent sensemaking, extending inferential accounts of legitimacy to the domain of generative AI and repositioning innovation diffusion as contingent on how creative processes are governed. Second, it provides empirical evidence that transparency is not a neutral governance intervention but a contingent mechanism whose effects depend critically on timing, contributing to debates on AI disclosure and responsible innovation. Third, it specifies the microfoundational mechanisms through which legitimacy breaks down and is partially reconstructed, identifying perceived deception, human effort, authenticity, and creativity as the inferential pathways through which governance practices shape evaluative and behavioral responses. While the empirical focus is on creative production, the theoretical framework applies to a wider set of innovations marked by algorithmic opacity and ambiguous agency. The findings therefore inform debates on the governance and evaluation of AI-driven innovation across several sectors.

The remainder of the paper is structured as follows. The next section develops the theoretical framework, conceptualizing legitimacy as an inferential process, and examining the role of governance under conditions of AI-mediated opacity. This is followed by the research hypotheses, methodology, results, and a discussion of theoretical, managerial, and policy implications.

2. Theoretical framework

2.1. Innovation legitimacy as an inferential process

Innovation legitimacy is commonly understood as a social evaluation through which new practices, technologies, or organizational forms come to be perceived as appropriate and acceptable within a system of shared norms and expectations (Bunduchi, 2017; Nowacki and Monk, 2020). In foundational work on legitimacy, it is commonly treated as a relatively stable property of innovations, arising from their alignment with established cognitive, normative, or pragmatic frameworks (Suchman, 1995). This view assumes that legitimacy-relevant information about production and authorship is embedded in observable outcomes.

A complementary body of research adopts a more processual view, conceptualizing legitimacy as the outcome of inferential judgments through which social actors attribute intentionality, competence, responsibility, and moral appropriateness to innovation producers (Strang and Meyer, 1993; Suddaby et al., 2017). From this perspective, legitimacy resides not in the artifact itself, but in the plausibility of the inference observers can draw about its conditions of production. This study draws on three complementary theoretical frameworks to develop and situate this inferential perspective. Signaling theory (Spence, 1973) provides the foundation for understanding why output quality has historically functioned as a credible signal of human effort and competence, and why gen-AI disrupts this signaling logic by lowering the cost of producing high-quality outputs independently of human involvement. Socio-cognitive legitimacy theory (Suchman, 1995) explains why the loss of comprehensible production cues generates evaluative uncertainty: when audiences can no longer construct a plausible account of how an artifact was produced, legitimacy judgments become cognitively unstable. Institutional theory (Meyer and Rowan, 1977) accounts for why governance mechanisms become central under these conditions, as formal practices of disclosure, oversight, and normative framing substitute for the broken inferential cues and provide the ceremonial scaffolding through which legitimacy can be partially reconstructed. Together, these frameworks motivate the reconceptualization of innovation legitimacy as a governance-dependent inferential process.

In conventional creative and innovation settings, outputs provide the primary basis for inferential judgments. Attributes such as quality, originality, coherence, and complexity function as signals of human effort, expertise, and intentionality (Hirsch, 1972; Massi et al., 2020). Through these signals, audiences establish a cognitive and moral linkage between creative artifacts and the actors responsible for their production, thereby sustaining relatively stable legitimacy judgments (Bitektine and Haack, 2015). This inferential logic becomes fragile when outputs no longer function as indicators of production conditions. Under technological opacity, outputs may perform effectively while conveying little information about human involvement, effort, or intentional control (Lee, 2022). In such cases, outputs lose their diagnostic value, and legitimacy judgments depend on alternative interpretive cues (Haack et al., 2021; Grimmelikhuijsen and Meijer, 2022; Kalpokiene and Kalpokas, 2023; Grange et al., 2026). Thus, innovation legitimacy can be understood as a sensemaking process activated under conditions of

inferential uncertainty. Audiences do not evaluate creative innovations solely in terms of utility or quality, but seek to resolve questions of agency, intention, and rule adherence as part of micro-level legitimacy judgments (Bitektine and Haack, 2015; Haack et al., 2021; Massi et al., 2025). When such questions cannot be answered through outputs alone, legitimacy becomes more contingent and dependent on supplementary sources of meaning. Gen-AI makes this reconceptualization particularly salient, as the separation between output and production processes is a structural feature of the technology. The formation of legitimacy judgments under these conditions departs from traditional inferential cues, with consequences for how AI-mediated innovation is evaluated and diffused (Glikson and Woolley, 2020; Martin and Waldman, 2023). Framed in this way, innovation legitimacy rests on micro-level judgments through which individuals interpret and assign meaning to innovative practices. When aggregated, these judgments underpin legitimacy perceptions at the organizational or field level (Bitektine and Haack, 2015; Haack et al., 2021). Gen-AI makes these microfoundational processes particularly visible by disrupting the cues on which such judgments typically rely.

2.2. Gen-AI and the radical decoupling of output quality from human agency

The inferential perspective on legitimacy is particularly consequential in the context of generative artificial intelligence, which introduces a radical decoupling between output quality and human agency in the production process (Mayer et al., 2025; Mills and Sætra, 2025; Tigre Moura et al., 2023). Unlike earlier forms of automation, gen-AI produces sophisticated creative outputs that no longer reliably signal the extent of human effort, intentionality, or control involved in their creation (Marzi and Balzano, 2025). While AI can function as a collaborative partner that enhances human creativity when deployed as a supportive tool (Agboola and Yassin, 2025), the shift toward fully AI-generated outputs severs this collaborative logic, removing the human agency that audiences expect to underlie creative work.

In traditional creative domains, output quality has functioned as a proxy for human competence and commitment, enabling the attribution of symbolic and moral value to creative artifacts (Hirsch, 1972; Becker, 1982). Gen-AI disrupts this proxy through a precise mechanism: it radically reduces the cost of producing high-quality creative outputs, thereby breaking the cost-based credibility of quality as a signal (Spence, 1973). In signaling theory, a signal is credible only when it is costly enough to be difficult to imitate by low-effort producers. When gen-AI makes high-quality output accessible at minimal effort, quality ceases to function as a costly and therefore credible signal of human agency and competence. Highly refined outputs may reflect minimal human input while substantial effort remains invisible (Tigre Moura et al., 2023), producing what can be described as a hollow signal: an output that appears high quality but carries no reliable information about the conditions of its production. This decoupling constitutes a structural shift in the foundations of legitimacy evaluation, operating at a deeper level than prior forms of organizational decoupling examined in institutional theory (Bromley and Powell, 2012). Here, decoupling does not occur between formal practices and substantive activities, but between the artifact itself and the human agency that audiences expect to underlie it. When outputs no longer function as proxies for human agency, audiences lose access to the heuristics traditionally used to assess authenticity, intention, and moral appropriateness. The result is a condition of inferential uncertainty in which output quality alone is insufficient to sustain legitimacy judgments (Bitektine and Haack, 2015).

While the innovation literature has long examined forms of decoupling between formal practices and substantive activities (Bromley and Powell, 2012), gen-AI operates at a deeper level. Here, decoupling affects the relationship between artifact and human agency itself, producing innovations that may appear fully functional and aesthetically convincing while remaining morally ambiguous from the perspective of external audiences (Introna, 2007; Massi et al., 2025). This ambiguity becomes particularly acute in the presence of highly realistic synthetic media and deepfakes. In these settings, creative outputs do more than obscure human agency: they may prompt misleading attributions regarding origin and intent (De Ruiter, 2021). As a consequence, creative production can be interpreted as deceptive or manipulative, even when no deliberate misrepresentation is involved. From a theoretical standpoint, this condition reveals a latent tension between functional and moral value in the evaluation of innovation. An innovation may be judged technically effective while simultaneously perceived as socially problematic when the process that generated it cannot be plausibly reconstructed. Thus, gen-AI constitutes an extreme empirical case of radical decoupling between output quality and human agency, undermining the inferential mechanisms that have traditionally sustained innovation legitimacy (Floridi et al., 2018; Conotter et al., 2014; Mills and Sætra, 2025; Oksanen et al., 2023).

2.3. Creative governance as an interpretive foundation of legitimacy

When creative outputs no longer function as reliable indicators of human agency and production conditions, legitimacy judgments do not disappear. Rather, they shift toward alternative interpretive foundations that can resolve the inferential uncertainty generated by radical decoupling between outputs and underlying processes (Xiong et al., 2026; Cimino et al., 2025). Under these conditions, the governance of creativity becomes central, as it provides audiences with cues through which innovative processes can be rendered interpretable and evaluable (Buhmann and Fieseler, 2023).

Moving beyond instrumental views that treat governance primarily as control or compliance, governance can be understood as an interpretive resource. This conceptualization departs from classical institutional accounts in which governance generates legitimacy directly through ceremonial conformity and isomorphic alignment with institutional expectations (Meyer and Rowan, 1977). In those accounts, governance acts as a legitimacy-producing mechanism whose effects are relatively automatic and stable. By contrast, in AI-mediated creativity, governance operates as an interpretive infrastructure: it does not produce legitimacy directly but shapes the conditions under which audiences can form legitimacy judgments when conventional output-based cues are absent. The distinction is consequential: governance can be formally present and normatively appropriate while failing to stabilize legitimacy judgments if audiences lack the interpretive resources to reconstruct agency and responsibility from the available cues. In this sense, this interpretive infrastructure provides the symbolic and cognitive foundations through which intentionality, responsibility, and moral appropriateness are attributed to creative processes (Busuioc, 2021). Thus, creative governance functions as a sensemaking infrastructure, enabling a plausible linkage between innovation and human agency when such a linkage cannot be inferred from outputs alone (Araki and Martins, 2024). In AI-mediated creativity, practices such as disclosing the role of AI, signaling human oversight, and articulating normative constraints constitute salient forms of creative governance. These practices communicate how creative processes are organized and according to which rules, thereby shaping judgments of authenticity, trust, and legitimacy (Lanfranchi et al., 2025; Baeyaert, 2025; Agboola, 2024). A critical dimension of creative governance concerns the timing of transparency. Prior research demonstrates that transparency is not neutral, but contingent, with effects that vary systematically depending on when disclosure occurs (Bernstein, 2012; Ananny and Crawford, 2018). When gen-AI involvement is disclosed ex-ante, transparency frames interpretation from the outset, reducing the likelihood of erroneous inferences and perceptions of deception. Under these conditions, governance signals can partially stabilize legitimacy judgments despite the absence of output-based cues (Bitektine and Haack, 2015). When disclosure occurs ex-post, transparency no longer guides sensemaking

but triggers retrospective reinterpretation and may be perceived as a violation of normative expectations. In such cases, governance functions as symbolic repair, mitigating perceptions of deception but rarely fully restoring legitimacy (Daly et al., 2025). In contexts of heightened ambiguity, such as deepfakes, governance cannot guarantee legitimacy but only shape the conditions under which it may be partially reconstructed (Vaccari and Chadwick, 2020). In AI-generated creativity, innovation legitimacy relies less on the properties of creative outputs than on perceptions that creative processes have been governed responsibly and in alignment with shared norms. Therefore, creative governance functions as a central interpretive mechanism through which meaning and legitimacy are reconstructed when traditional output-based inferential cues no longer hold (Bitektine and Haack, 2015; Busuioc, 2021; Vaccari and Chadwick, 2020). These arguments provide the basis for examining how AI involvement, inferential decoupling, and governance practices shape individual evaluations of creative content.

3. Research hypotheses

Legitimacy judgments in AI-mediated creativity are conceptualized here as inferential processes through which audiences assess the moral appropriateness and normative acceptability of creative production (Suchman, 1995; Bitektine and Haack, 2015), specifically inferences concerning perceived deception, perceived human effort, and perceived authenticity. These judgments are analytically distinguished from their downstream consequences: attitude toward the organization captures whether legitimacy judgments generalize to evaluations of the producing entity (Suchman, 1995; Bitektine and Haack, 2015), while behavioral intentions provide a criterion for assessing whether such judgments carry actionable consequences beyond attitudinal responses. This distinction clarifies the causal structure of the model: experimental conditions shape inferential mechanisms, which in turn drive evaluative and behavioral outcomes. The hypotheses below specify how features of AI involvement, governance conditions, and individual characteristics systematically influence these inferential processes.

3.1. The role of AI in creative production

When creative content is generated primarily by AI systems, audiences have limited access to cues that traditionally signal human agency, intentionality, and effort. This opacity disrupts the inferential heuristics through which authenticity and legitimacy are typically assessed (Glikson and Woolley, 2020; Bunduchi, 2017). Even when observable output quality is held constant, the role attributed to AI in the production process shapes how the creative act itself is interpreted (Martin and Waldman, 2023). AI-generated content intensifies the decoupling between output quality and human agency in creative production (Bitektine and Haack, 2015; Mayer et al., 2025). When reliable signals of intentional human action are absent, audiences are more likely to experience a sense of inferential opacity, a condition in which the production process cannot be plausibly reconstructed from the output alone. It is this structural opacity that activates perceptions of deception, independently of any attributed intention to deceive. Perceived deception, as operationalized in this study, reflects a judgment about the communicative process itself, specifically the extent to which the absence of transparent human agency violates normative expectations of honesty and disclosure (Darke and Ritchie, 2007; Hancock et al., 2020). AI-generated content, by rendering human involvement invisible, creates precisely these conditions of normative violation, independently of whether any deliberate misrepresentation was intended. These inferences do not derive from the output itself, but from perceptions of how agency is distributed in the production process (Haack et al., 2021). The following hypotheses are derived:

H1a. Creative content that is AI-generated (vs. AI-assisted) is associated with higher perceived deception.

H1b. Creative content that is AI-generated (vs. AI-assisted) is associated with lower perceived human effort.

H1c. Creative content that is AI-generated (vs. AI-assisted) is associated with lower perceived authenticity.

3.2. Transparency timing as a governance mechanism

The governance of AI-mediated creativity shapes legitimacy judgments by structuring how audiences interpret opaque production processes (Floridi, 2024; Mills and Sætra, 2025). Among governance practices, transparency plays a particularly consequential role, not simply through disclosure per se, but through the timing with which information about AI involvement is revealed. Transparency timing determines whether governance operates as an ex-ante interpretive frame or as an ex-post corrective intervention (Formosa et al., 2025).

When AI involvement is disclosed ex-ante, transparency provides audiences with an interpretive context before evaluative inferences are formed. By clarifying the configuration of agency in advance, early disclosure reduces the likelihood of erroneous attributions, attenuates suspicions of deception, and stabilizes inferences concerning human effort and authenticity (Bernstein, 2012; Ananny and Crawford, 2018). Under these conditions, governance signals can partially compensate for the inferential uncertainty introduced by AI-generated content.

By contrast, when AI involvement is disclosed ex-post, transparency no longer guides sensemaking but instead prompts retrospective reinterpretation. Audiences are required to revise inferences already formed under incomplete information, often interpreting delayed disclosure as a violation of normative expectations concerning honesty and consent. In such cases, transparency functions as a form of symbolic repair, with limited capacity to restore legitimacy once perceptions of deception have been activated (Daly et al., 2025). Accordingly, transparency timing is expected to mediate the effects of AI involvement on inferential mechanisms, with asymmetric consequences depending on whether disclosure occurs before or after exposure to the creative content. We therefore hypothesize:

H2a. Ex-post disclosure of AI involvement is associated with higher perceived deception than ex-ante disclosure.

H2b. Ex-post disclosure of AI involvement is associated with lower perceived human effort than ex-ante disclosure.

H2c. Ex-post disclosure of AI involvement is associated with lower perceived authenticity than ex-ante disclosure.

3.3. Deepfake risk and inferential uncertainty

Beyond the role of AI in creation and transparency timing, the presence of deepfake-related cues introduces a distinct source of inferential uncertainty in the evaluation of creative content. Deepfakes and highly realistic synthetic media have been shown to undermine audiences' ability to reliably infer origin, intention, and responsibility, thereby challenging established mechanisms of trust and legitimacy (Chesney and Citron, 2019; Vaccari and Chadwick, 2020). When deepfake risk is salient, audiences are more likely to question the integrity of the creative process and to doubt the intentions of those responsible for the content. Prior research suggests that such cues heighten moral and epistemic concerns, leading individuals to infer higher levels of deception and to discount the authenticity of mediated outputs, even in the absence of direct evidence of manipulation (De Ruiter, 2021). In addition, deepfake-related cues may function as indicators of extensive algorithmic intervention, thereby reducing perceived human effort in the creative process (Floridi et al., 2018; Tigre Moura et al., 2023).

Importantly, these effects are expected to occur independently of the observable quality of the output. Even when creative content appears coherent, original, or aesthetically refined, the presence of deepfake risk disrupts the inferential cues through which agency, intentionality, and

responsibility are typically attributed (Haack et al., 2021). As a result, deepfake risk operates as a general stimulus that activates inferential mechanisms central to legitimacy judgments in AI-mediated creativity. We hypothesize:

H3a. The presence of deepfake risk cues is associated with higher perceived deception.

H3b. The presence of deepfake risk cues is associated with lower perceived human effort.

H3c. The presence of deepfake risk cues is associated with lower perceived authenticity.

3.4. Inferential mechanisms and evaluative outcomes

Conceptualizing legitimacy as an inferential process implies that evaluations of AI-mediated creativity are shaped by how audiences interpret opaque production processes, and not by observable outcomes alone (Bitektine and Haack, 2015; Haack et al., 2021). When traditional cues of human agency are weakened, individuals rely on inferences concerning deception, human effort, and authenticity to assess the normative acceptability and value of creative outputs (Suchman, 1995; Glikson and Woolley, 2020). These inferential mechanisms, in turn, have systematic consequences for attitudinal and behavioral responses.

The mapping between inferential mechanisms and evaluative outcomes is theoretically asymmetric and reflects a conceptual distinction between judgments of the communicative act and judgments of the producing entity (MacKenzie and Lutz, 1989; Suchman, 1995). Perceived deception is a moral judgment anchored to the communicative process itself, specifically to whether the message was constructed and transmitted in ways that violate expectations of honesty and transparency (Darke and Ritchie, 2007; Ananny and Crawford, 2018; Hancock et al., 2020). As such, it is expected to shape attitudes toward the message transmission, since the inference of deception is directed at the act of communication and not at the identity of the emitter. Perceived authenticity, by contrast, is a judgment about the actor, capturing inferences concerning the sincerity, integrity, and normative responsibility of the entity that produces and disseminates the content (Bitektine and Haack, 2015). It is therefore expected to shape attitudes toward the organization, since authenticity is an attribute of the source and not of the communicative text. This asymmetric structure reflects established distinctions in persuasion research between message-level and source-level evaluations, and in legitimacy theory between judgments of specific practices and judgments of the organizational actor. Retaining three outcome variables is therefore theoretically motivated: each captures a distinct level of evaluation, namely the communicative act, the producing entity, and downstream behavioral responses, and collapsing them into a single outcome would obscure the multilevel nature of legitimacy judgments in AI-mediated creativity. Perceived human effort and perceived authenticity also inform evaluative judgments of creativity by signaling intentionality and expressive commitment in the creative process (Magni et al., 2024). When creative outputs are perceived as lacking human effort or authenticity, they are less likely to be judged as genuinely creative.

Thus, perceived creativity functions as an intermediate evaluative outcome that synthesizes upstream inferential judgments and translates them into downstream behavioral intentions, such as willingness to engage with or support the creative output (Im et al., 2015; Chu et al., 2024). Perceived deception and perceived authenticity do not act directly on behavioral intentions because their effects are channeled through more proximal evaluative judgments: deception shapes attitudes toward the communicative act, authenticity shapes attitudes toward the organization, and both contribute to creativity evaluations. Perceived creativity therefore occupies a distinct position in the causal structure: it is not an independent inferential dimension but an emergent evaluative synthesis that integrates prior assessments of effort and authenticity into a higher-order judgment of expressive value, functioning as the cognitive bridge through which inferential legitimacy judgments acquire actionable behavioral consequences (Bitektine and Haack, 2015). We hypothesize:

H4a. Higher perceived deception is associated with less favorable attitudes toward the message transmission.

H4b. Higher perceived authenticity is associated with more favorable attitudes toward the organization.

H4c. Higher perceived human effort and authenticity are associated with higher perceived creativity.

H4d. Higher perceived creativity is associated with stronger behavioral intentions.

3.5. Individual-level dispositional antecedents

Consistent with an inferential perspective, responses to AI-mediated creativity are also shaped by individual-level dispositions that influence how ambiguous production cues are interpreted. These dispositions function as antecedents conditions that modulate the sensitivity of inferential processes to cues of technological opacity and agency ambiguity (Bitektine and Haack, 2015; Haack et al., 2021). Audiences vary systematically in their orientation toward organizational communication and technology, leading to predictable differences in how inferential mechanisms are activated independently of experimental conditions.

Individuals characterized by higher levels of skepticism or psychological reactance are more likely to interpret AI-mediated creative processes as normatively problematic, heightening concerns related to deception, reduced human effort, and diminished authenticity (Darke and Ritchie, 2007). By contrast, individuals with greater trust in technology or higher familiarity with AI are less reliant on traditional agency-based cues and are therefore less prone to negative inferential interpretations. Accordingly, we hypothesize:

H5a. Higher levels of audience skepticism and trait psychological reactance are associated with stronger perceptions of deception, lower perceived human effort, and lower perceived authenticity in AI-mediated creative contexts.

H5b. Higher levels of trust in technology and greater familiarity with AI are associated with lower perceptions of deception, higher perceived human effort, and higher perceived authenticity in AI-mediated creative contexts.

Fig. 1 depicts the inferential model developed in this study, highlighting the shift from output-based evaluation to process-based legitimacy judgments in AI-mediated creativity.

4. Methodology

4.1. Research design and experimental setup

To examine how audiences evaluate AI-mediated creative content under conditions of inferential uncertainty, we conducted a survey-based experiment employing a between-subjects factorial design. The study focuses on situations in which observable creative outputs provide limited or ambiguous information about the underlying production process, thereby requiring individuals to rely on inferential judgments to assess agency, authenticity, and legitimacy. Participants were randomly assigned to one of eight experimental conditions in a 2 (AI role in creation: AI-generated vs. AI-assisted) × 2 (transparency timing: disclosure ex-ante vs. discovery ex-post) × 2 (deepfake-like manipulation: absent vs. present) design. Random assignment resulted in a balanced distribution of participants across the eight experimental conditions, with 30 observations per condition. This structure enables the independent

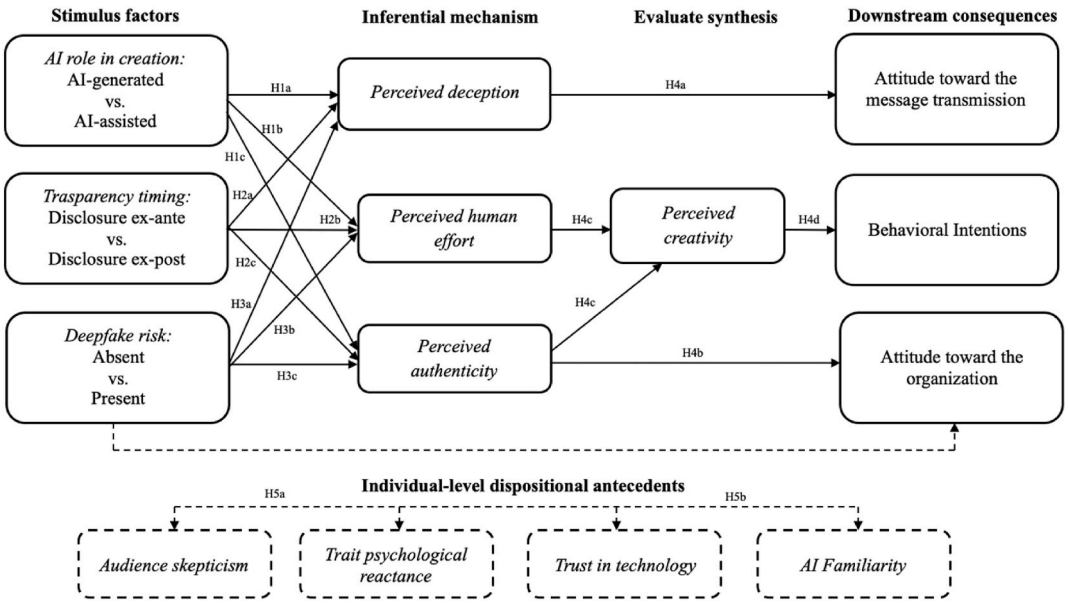


Fig. 1. Inferential model of legitimacy judgments and downstream outcomes in AI-generated creativity under deepfake uncertainty.

examination of production configuration, governance signals, and manipulation risk, as well as their combined effects on inferential mechanisms and downstream evaluations. Across all conditions, the creative output itself was held constant. Experimental variation was introduced exclusively through contextual information describing how the content was produced, disclosed, and framed. This design choice ensures that observed differences in responses are attributable to inferential processes. A detailed overview of the eight experimental scenarios (C1–C8) is shown in Table 1.

4.2. Experimental manipulations

The role of AI in creation was manipulated by varying whether the content was described as being generated primarily by an AI system or produced through a human-led creative process supported by AI tools. In the AI-generated condition, AI was presented as the principal creative agent responsible for the output. In the AI-assisted condition, AI was framed as a supportive tool operating under human direction.

Transparency timing was manipulated by varying when participants became aware of AI involvement. In the ex-ante disclosure condition, information about AI use was provided prior to exposure to the content, allowing it to function as an interpretive frame. In the ex-post discovery condition, AI involvement was revealed only after initial exposure, simulating delayed disclosure or external discovery.

Deepfake-like manipulation was operationalized through cues indicating the presence of highly realistic synthetic elements designed to closely resemble the voice of a real well-known public figure. In the manipulation-present condition, participants were informed of such synthetic features; in the manipulation-absent condition, no such cues were provided.

Manipulation checks were included to verify that participants correctly perceived the experimental manipulations. After exposure to the stimulus, respondents indicated (i) whether the content was primarily AI-generated or AI-assisted, (ii) whether AI involvement was disclosed before exposure or discovered only after exposure, and (iii) whether the stimulus involved deepfake-like synthetic manipulation cues. The manipulation checks shown in Table 2 confirmed that participants correctly identified the intended condition assignments.

An example of the video stimulus is provided in Appendix A to illustrate the format and visual characteristics of the content.

Table 1
Overview of experimental conditions.

Condition	AI Role	Transparency Timing	Deepfake-like Manipulation	Brief Description
C1	AI-generated	Disclosed ex-ante	Absent	AI-generated content with upfront disclosure; no synthetic manipulation
C2	AI-generated	Disclosed ex-ante	Present	AI-generated content with upfront disclosure and synthetic manipulation cue
C3	AI-assisted	Disclosed ex-ante	Absent	Human-led content with AI support disclosed upfront; no synthetic manipulation
C4	AI-assisted	Disclosed ex-ante	Present	Human-led content with AI support disclosed upfront and synthetic manipulation cue
C5	AI-generated	Discovered ex-post	Absent	AI-generated content with delayed discovery of AI use; no synthetic manipulation
C6	AI-generated	Discovered ex-post	Present	AI-generated content with delayed discovery and synthetic manipulation cue
C7	AI-assisted	Discovered ex-post	Absent	Human-led content with AI support discovered ex-post; no synthetic manipulation
C8	AI-assisted	Discovered ex-post	Present	Human-led content with AI support discovered ex-post and synthetic manipulation cue

Authors' elaboration.

Table 2
Manipulation checks.

Manipulation	Measure	Condition	% Correct Identification	Test statistic	p-value
AI role in content creation	Perceived role of AI (AI-generated vs. AI-assisted)	AI-generated	95.8%	χ^2 (df = 1) = 10.80	< 0.001
		AI-assisted	85.7%		
Transparency timing	Perceived timing of AI disclosure (ex-ante vs. ex-post)	Disclosed ex-ante	98.3%	χ^2 (df = 1) = 8.17	0.004
		Discovered ex-post	89.0%		
Deepfake-like manipulation	Presence of synthetic manipulation cues (present vs. absent)	Present	87.4%	χ^2 (df = 1) = 7.63	0.006
		Absent	80.8%		

Note. Manipulation checks were administered after stimulus exposure. Percentages indicate the proportion of participants correctly identifying the intended experimental condition. Chi-square tests of independence compare the frequency of correct versus incorrect identification across experimental conditions.

4.3. Sample and procedure

Data were collected through an online survey administered to adult participants recruited through a convenience sampling approach via professional networks and social media channels, including LinkedIn. Recruitment was conducted across multiple countries to ensure cross-national variation in the sample. Participants were randomly assigned to one experimental condition and exposed to the corresponding stimulus. Participants were exposed to a short video stimulus (around 15 s) corresponding to their assigned experimental condition (C1-C8). The video presented a creative message whose visual and narrative content remained constant across conditions. Experimental variation was introduced exclusively through contextual information describing the role of AI in the creative process, the timing of disclosure, and the presence or absence of deepfake-like manipulation cues. After viewing the content, respondents completed a questionnaire measuring inferential mechanisms, evaluative outcomes, behavioral intentions, and individual-level characteristics.

The final sample consisted of 240 respondents, with a balanced distribution across experimental conditions. Standard demographic variables were collected and used for descriptive purposes and robustness checks. An overview of the preliminary sample characteristics is reported in Table 3.

The survey was administered in both Italian and English. To ensure semantic equivalence and cross-language validity, all materials underwent a translation and back-translation process. Four independent language experts with academic and professional expertise reviewed the survey instruments and validated the equivalence of the two versions. Minor wording adjustments were made to ensure conceptual consistency across languages.

4.4. Measures

All constructs were measured using established multi-item scales adapted to the study context. Unless otherwise indicated, items were measured on seven-point Likert-type scales. For brevity, only illustrative items are reported below; the full list of items, sources, and scale rationales is provided in Appendix B.

Perceived deception was assessed using five items capturing the extent to which the message transmission was perceived as misleading or manipulative, reflecting a judgment about the communicative process (e.g., "The way this message was communicated feels manipulative"), drawing on prior work on deception and persuasion in mediated communication (Darke and Ritchie, 2007; Chaouachi and Rached, 2012).

Perceived human effort was measured with five items capturing the degree of deliberate human involvement attributed to the creation of the message (e.g., "A substantial amount of human effort went into creating this message"), based on research on effort attribution, agency, and authenticity (Newman et al., 2014; Mourey et al., 2017; Inzlicht et al., 2018).

Perceived creativity was assessed using five items reflecting originality, imagination, and innovativeness in message transmission (e.g., "The way this message was communicated feels creative"), drawing on established creativity scales (Runco and Jaeger, 2012; Dahlén et al., 2008).

Perceived authenticity was measured using five items capturing sincerity, integrity, and responsible communication (e.g., "The way this message was communicated feels genuine"), adapted from prior research on brand and communication authenticity (Beverland, 2005; Morhart et al., 2015; Napoli et al., 2014).

Evaluative outcomes included *attitude toward the message transmission* and *attitude toward the organization*, both measured using standard semantic differential scales commonly employed in persuasion and advertising research (Mitchell and Olson, 1981; MacKenzie and Lutz, 1989). *Behavioral intentions* were assessed through three items capturing willingness to engage with, share, and attend to future messages from the organization (Baumsteiger and Siegel, 2019).

Individual-level dispositional antecedents included *audience skepticism*, measured using items adapted from persuasion knowledge and advertising skepticism research (Friestad and Wright, 1994; Obermiller et al., 2005); *trait psychological reactance*, assessed using established reactance scales (Hong and Curran, 2019; Shen and Dillard, 2005); *trust in technology*, capturing general confidence in automated systems (Lee, 2022; Mcknight et al., 2011); and *AI familiarity*, measured as self-reported familiarity with generative AI (gen-AI) tools (Glikson and Woolley, 2020).

Table 3
Sample characteristics.

Variable	Category	Frequency	Percentage
Country	Italy	133	55.4%
	UK	53	22.1%
	Philippines	36	15%
	Other	18	7.5%
Age	60+	13	5.4%
	45-59	13	5.4%
	35-44	62	25.8%
	25-34	147	61.3%
	18-24	5	2.1%
Social media usage	Several times a day	203	84.6%
	About once a day	17	7.1%
	A few times a week	13	5.4%
	Less often	5	2.1%
	Never	2	0.8%

Authors' elaboration.

4.5. Analytical strategy

All analyses were conducted using IBM SPSS Statistics 26, following established procedures for estimating sequential relationships among cognitive evaluations and outcomes (Hayes, 2018). Hypotheses were tested using regression-based analytical techniques consistent with the inferential framework developed in this study. The analytical strategy focused on estimating the associations between experimental conditions, inferential judgments, and evaluative outcomes, as well as the role of individual-level characteristics shaping inferential responses. Regression models were estimated with robust standard errors. The analysis adopts a sequential inferential logic in which judgments of

deception, human effort, authenticity, and creativity operate as interpretive mechanisms linking production configurations to evaluative and behavioral outcomes. This approach reflects a theoretically motivated sequential structure in which legitimacy judgments are conceptualized as emergent outcomes of sensemaking processes.

To assess the practical significance of the estimated effects, Cohen's f^2 is reported alongside each regression coefficient as a measure of effect size, calculated from partial R^2 values. Following conventional benchmarks, f^2 values of 0.02, 0.15, and 0.35 indicate small, medium, and large effects respectively (Cohen, 1988).

To assess the robustness of the main findings, all regression models in Table 7 were re-estimated including age and social media usage frequency as demographic covariates. The direction and statistical significance of the key coefficients remained substantively unchanged across all models, with the exception of H1c, which showed only marginal significance in the base model and became non-significant when demographic controls were included, consistent with the weak support already reported for this hypothesis. Demographic covariates did not reach conventional significance thresholds in any model, confirming that the experimental effects are not confounded by sample composition.

5. Results

5.1. Measurement properties and inferential constructs

The constructs employed in this study capture inferential judgments through which audiences evaluate AI-mediated creative content under conditions of opacity. All multi-item measures exhibited satisfactory internal consistency, with Cronbach's alpha values exceeding commonly accepted thresholds. Table 4 reports factor loadings, distributional properties, and reliability and validity indicators for all constructs.

As shown in Table 4, all items load strongly on their intended constructs, with standardized loadings exceeding commonly accepted thresholds. Internal consistency is supported by Cronbach's alpha (α) and composite reliability values well above recommended cutoffs. Average variance extracted (AVE) values indicate satisfactory convergent validity across constructs. Skewness and kurtosis statistics fall within acceptable ranges, suggesting no severe departures from normality. Variance inflation factors (VIFs) remain below conservative thresholds, alleviating concerns regarding multicollinearity.

Inter-construct correlations indicated adequate discriminant validity, suggesting that perceived deception, perceived human effort, perceived authenticity, and perceived creativity capture related but distinct inferential mechanisms. No correlation approached levels that would raise concerns regarding multicollinearity. The full correlation matrix is reported in Table 5.

Discriminant validity was established using the Fornell–Larcker

Table 4
Measurement properties, reliability, and convergent validity.

Variables	Items	Loadings	Kurtosis	Skewness	α	CR	AVE	VIF
Perceived Deception (PD)	PD1	0.854	−0.888	−0.354	0.888	0.911	0.671	2.049
	PD2	0.832	−0.756	−0.337				
	PD3	0.811	−0.912	−0.135				
	PD4	0.799	−0.845	−0.198				
	PD5	0.798	−0.843	−0.145				
Perceived Human Effort (PHE)	PHE1	0.876	0.335	−0.595	0.943	0.929	0.723	2.119
	PHE2	0.855	0.041	−0.634				
	PHE3	0.845	−0.031	−0.770				
	PHE4	0.841	−0.300	−0.669				
	PHE5	0.833	−0.108	−0.812				
Perceived Creativity (PC)	PC1	0.929	−0.876	−0.159	0.834	0.929	0.725	1.960
	PC2	0.908	−0.826	−0.123				
	PC3	0.876	−0.945	−0.357				
	PC4	0.779	−0.855	−0.234				
	PC5	0.750	−0.789	−0.212				
Perceived Authenticity (PA)	PA1	0.857	−0.126	−0.679	0.883	0.907	0.660	1.690
	PA2	0.836	−0.336	−0.314				
	PA3	0.800	−0.516	−0.539				
	PA4	0.798	0.198	−1.022				
	PA5	0.769	−0.707	−0.127				
Attitude toward the message transmission (ATMT)	ATMT1	0.893	0.186	−0.784	0.875	0.911	0.774	2.178
	ATMT2	0.891	−0.439	−0.326				
	ATMT3	0.854	0.176	−0.916				
Attitude toward the organization (ATO)	ATO1	0.921	0.378	−1.076	0.899	0.925	0.804	1.973
	ATO2	0.901	0.245	−0.804				
	ATO3	0.867	−0.001	−0.986				
Behavioral Intentions (BI)	BI1	0.883	0.712	−0.458	0.872	0.889	0.728	1.997
	BI2	0.845	−0.309	−0.564				
	BI3	0.831	0.329	−0.121				
Audience Skepticism (AS)	AS1	0.923	−0.423	−0.134	0.913	0.914	0.842	1.193
	AS2	0.912	−0.832	−0.366				
Trait Psychological Reactance (TPR)	TPR1	0.963	−0.793	−0.832	0.886	0.955	0.842	1.037
	TPR2	0.952	−0.722	−0.374				
	TPR3	0.945	−0.692	−0.372				
	TPR4	0.801	−0.317	−0.444				
Trust in Technology (TT)	TT1	0.894	0.135	−0.367	0.912	0.888	0.726	2.135
	TT2	0.870	0.455	−0.871				
	TT3	0.789	−0.566	−0.409				
AI Familiarity (AIF)	AIF1	0.841	−0.214	−0.611	0.825	0.860	0.672	2.094
	AIF2	0.815	−0.781	−0.369				
	AIF3	0.803	−0.459	−0.376				

Authors' elaboration.

Table 5
Correlation matrix.

Constructs	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11
1. PD	1.00										
2. PHE	−0.283**	1.00									
3. PA	−0.256**	0.477**	1.00								
4. PC	−0.449**	0.573**	0.686**	1.00							
5. ATMT	−0.326**	0.256**	0.569**	0.427**	1.00						
6. ATO	0.023	0.244**	0.439**	0.437**	0.237**	1.00					
7. BI	−0.443**	0.083	−0.079	0.540**	0.473**	0.480**	1.00				
8. AS	0.112	−0.105	−0.175**	−0.137*	0.185**	−0.204**	0.417**	1.00			
9. TPR	−0.209**	0.265**	−0.269**	0.251**	0.194**	0.060	0.059	0.140*	1.00		
10. TT	0.175**	0.055	0.023	−0.023	−0.012	−0.083	−0.195**	0.039	−0.046	1.00	
11. AIF	0.013	−0.112	−0.058	−0.018	−0.070	0.058	−0.001	−0.109	0.012	−0.222**	1.00

Note. Statistical significance is assessed at the 10%, 5%, and 1% levels. Authors' elaboration.
*p < .10, **p < .05, ***p < .01.

criterion, as the square root of AVE for each construct exceeded its correlations with other constructs. Table 6 reports the Fornell–Larcker criterion, showing adequate discriminant validity across all constructs.

5.2. Effects of AI role in creative production

Inferential judgments differ systematically across production configurations, disclosure regimes, and exposure to synthetic manipulation cues. The analysis directly tests hypotheses H1a–H1c, H2a–H2c, and H3a–H3c. Table 7 reports the full set of regression estimates for these analyses.

With respect to the role of production configuration, content described as primarily generated through automated means is associated with significantly higher perceived deception than content produced through a human-led process with technological support (H1a). The estimated effect is positive and substantial (b = 0.68, p < .001), indicating that lower visibility of human agency is associated with stronger inferences of misleading or manipulative intent. H1a is therefore supported. Production configuration also affects attributions of human effort. When content is described as generated, perceived human effort is significantly lower (b = −0.50, p = .003), providing support for H1b. By contrast, the effect of production configuration on perceived authenticity is weaker and only marginally significant (b = −0.29, p = .087). Accordingly, H1c receives weak support.

Turning to disclosure timing, delayed disclosure of technological involvement does not affect perceptions of deception (b = −0.03, p = .770), offering no support for H2a. However, disclosure timing has a pronounced effect on perceived human effort. When involvement is discovered after exposure, attributions of human effort are substantially reduced (b = −1.06, p < .001), supporting H2b. No significant effect is observed for perceived authenticity (b = −0.09, p = .586), and H2c is therefore not supported.

The presence of synthetic manipulation cues exerts a consistent influence across inferential judgments. Exposure to such cues increases perceived deception (b = 0.30, p = .001), reduces perceived human effort (b = −0.41, p = .009), and lowers perceived authenticity (b = −0.34, p = .001). These results provide support for H3a, H3b, and H3c.

5.3. Inferential judgments and evaluative outcomes

Evaluative and behavioral outcomes are shaped by inferential judgments concerning deception, human effort, authenticity, and creativity. The analysis tests hypotheses H4a–H4d, focusing on the role of inferential judgments as proximal drivers of attitudes and intentions. Table 8 reports the full set of regression estimates for these analyses.

Perceived deception is negatively associated with evaluations of the message transmission. Higher levels of perceived deception correspond to significantly less favorable attitudes toward the way the message is communicated (b = −0.46, p < .001). This result indicates that moral inferences concerning misleading or manipulative intent directly undermine message-level evaluations, supporting H4a.

Perceived authenticity is positively associated with evaluations of the organization responsible for the communication. Higher authenticity attributions correspond to more favorable organizational attitudes (b = 0.46, p < .001), suggesting that perceptions of sincerity and responsible conduct play a central role in shaping organizational evaluations. H4b is supported.

The results indicate that both inferential mechanisms proposed in H4c are significantly associated with perceived creativity. Perceived authenticity exhibits a strong positive relationship with creativity evaluations (b = 0.40, p < .001), while perceived human effort also shows a positive, albeit weaker, association (b = 0.14, p = .001). These findings support H4c and indicate that creativity judgments are shaped by multiple inferential cues, with authenticity playing a more central role than attributions of effort. Finally, perceived creativity is positively associated with behavioral intentions, including willingness to engage with and attend to future communications from the organization

Table 6
Fornell–larcker criterion.

Constructs	PD	PHE	PA	PC	ATMT	ATO	BI	AS	TPR	TT	AIF
PD	**0.819**										
PHE	−0.283	**0.850**									
PA	−0.256	0.477	**0.812**								
PC	−0.449	0.573	0.686	**0.851**							
ATMT	−0.326	0.256	0.569	0.427	**0.880**						
ATO	0.023	0.244	0.439	0.437	0.237	**0.897**					
BI	−0.443	0.083	−0.079	0.540	0.473	0.480	**0.853**				
AS	0.112	−0.105	−0.175	−0.137	0.185	−0.204	0.417	**0.918**			
TPR	−0.209	0.265	−0.269	0.251	0.194	0.060	0.059	0.140	**0.918**		
TT	0.175	0.055	0.023	−0.023	−0.012	−0.083	−0.195	0.039	−0.046	**0.852**	
AIF	0.013	−0.112	−0.058	−0.018	−0.070	0.058	−0.001	−0.109	0.012	−0.222	**0.820**

Note. √AVE on the diagonal Authors' elaboration.

Table 7
Effects of AI role, disclosure timing, and deepfake on inferential mechanisms (H1a–H1c; H2a–H2c; H3a–H3c).

Hypothesis	Dependent variable	Predictor	b	SE (robust)	p-value	f^2
H1a	**Perceived Deception**	AI-generated (vs. AI-assisted)	0.68	0.11	< 0.001***	0.162
H2a		Ex-post disclosure (vs. ex-ante)	−0.03	0.11	0.770	0.000
H3a		Deepfake risk (present vs. absent)	0.30	0.09	0.001***	0.047
H1b	**Perceived Human Effort**	AI-generated (vs. AI-assisted)	−0.50	0.15	0.003***	0.047
H2b		Ex-post disclosure (vs. ex-ante)	−1.06	0.14	< 0.001***	0.243
H3b		Deepfake risk (present vs. absent)	−0.41	0.16	0.009***	0.028
H1c	**Perceived Authenticity**	AI-generated (vs. AI-assisted)	−0.29	0.17	0.087*	0.012
H2c		Ex-post disclosure (vs. ex-ante)	−0.09	0.16	0.586	0.001
H3c		Deepfake risk (present vs. absent)	−0.34	0.11	0.001***	0.040

Note. Coefficients are unstandardized; robust standard errors reported. Authors' elaboration.
f^2 = Cohen's f^2 effect size based on partial R^2; benchmarks: small = 0.02, medium = 0.15, large = 0.35.
Statistical significance is assessed at the 10%, 5%, and 1% levels.
*p < .10, **p < .05, ***p < .01.

Table 8
Effects of inferential mechanisms on evaluative and behavioral outcomes (H4a–H4d).

Hypothesis	Dependent variable	Predictor	b	SE (robust)	p-value	f^2
H4a	**Attitude toward the message transmission**	Perceived Deception	−0.46	0.10	< 0.001***	0.089
H4b	**Attitude toward the organization**	Perceived Authenticity	0.46	0.05	< 0.001***	0.356
H4c	**Perceived Creativity**	Perceived Human Effort	0.14	0.04	0.001***	0.052
		Perceived Authenticity	0.40	0.07	< 0.001***	0.138
H4d	**Behavioral Intentions**	Perceived Creativity	0.42	0.08	< 0.001***	0.116

Note. Coefficients are unstandardized; robust standard errors reported. Authors' elaboration.
f^2 = Cohen's f^2 effect size based on partial R^2; benchmarks: small = 0.02, medium = 0.15, large = 0.35.
Statistical significance is assessed at the 10%, 5%, and 1% levels.
*p < .10, **p < .05, ***p < .01.

(b = 0.42, p < .001). This finding supports H4d and further supports the role of creativity as a proximal driver of behavioral responses.

5.4. Individual-level dispositional antecedents

Inferential judgments concerning deception, human effort, and authenticity vary with individual-level orientations toward organizational communication and technology. Table 9 reports the full set of regression estimates for these analyses.

Hypothesis H5a predicts that audience skepticism and trait psychological reactance shape negative inferential judgments. The results provide partial support for this hypothesis. Audience skepticism is negatively associated with perceived human effort (b = −0.37, p = .023) and marginally associated with perceived deception (b = 0.11, p = .069), but shows no significant relationship with perceived authenticity. Trait psychological reactance exhibits a different pattern. Higher reactance is associated with significantly lower perceived authenticity (b = −0.27, p = .014), while its associations with perceived deception and perceived human effort are not statistically significant. These findings indicate that skepticism and reactance shape inferential judgments through distinct pathways.

Hypothesis H5b concerns the role of trust in technology and familiarity with AI. The results again indicate partial support. Trust in technology is strongly associated with inferential judgments concerning agency and integrity. Higher trust corresponds to higher perceived human effort (b = 0.29, p < .001) and higher perceived authenticity (b = 0.33, p < .001), suggesting that confidence in automated systems is associated with different interpretations of agency in creative production. Trust in technology does not affect perceived deception.

AI familiarity shows a more limited pattern of effects. Greater familiarity is associated with higher perceived deception (b = 0.08, p = .018) but is unrelated to perceived human effort and authenticity.

Table 9
Effects of individual-level dispositional antecedents on inferential mechanisms (H5a–H5b).

Hypothesis	Dependent variable	Predictor	b	SE (robust)	p-value	f^2
H5a	Perceived Deception	Audience Skepticism	0.11	0.06	0.069*	0.014
		Psychological Reactance	−0.09	0.07	0.190	0.007
	Perceived Human Effort	Audience Skepticism	−0.37	0.16	0.023**	0.023
		Psychological Reactance	−0.05	0.12	0.684	0.001
	Perceived Authenticity	Audience Skepticism	0.03	0.12	0.826	0.000
		Psychological Reactance	−0.27	0.11	0.014**	0.025
H5b	Perceived Deception	Trust in Technology	0.00	0.03	0.901	0.000
		AI Familiarity	0.08	0.03	0.018**	0.030
	Perceived Human Effort	Trust in Technology	0.29	0.08	< 0.001***	0.055
		AI Familiarity	0.07	0.07	0.274	0.004
	Perceived Authenticity	Trust in Technology	0.33	0.07	< 0.001***	0.094
		AI Familiarity	−0.05	0.05	0.322	0.004

Note. Coefficients are unstandardized; robust standard errors reported. Authors' elaboration.
f^2 = Cohen's f^2 effect size based on partial R^2; benchmarks: small = 0.02, medium = 0.15, large = 0.35.
Statistical significance is assessed at the 10%, 5%, and 1% levels.
*p < .10, **p < .05, ***p < .01.

6. Discussion

The purpose of this study is to examine how legitimacy judgments are formed when creative outputs no longer provide reliable information about human effort, agency, and responsibility. The findings offer a theoretically consequential insight: under conditions of gen-AI, legitimacy is increasingly reconstructed through the governance of creative processes. This shift has important implications for innovation theory, particularly for research on legitimacy, diffusion, and responsible innovation in AI-mediated contexts.

6.1. Reframing innovation legitimacy under AI-mediated opacity: from output-based evaluation to governance-dependent diffusion

Innovation research has traditionally assumed that legitimacy can be inferred from observable outcomes, such as performance, quality, or originality, because these outcomes function as proxies for human competence, intention, and responsibility (Suchman, 1995; Hirsch, 1972; Bunduchi, 2017). This assumption supports much of the literature on innovation evaluation and diffusion, where legitimacy is treated as a stable outcome of alignment between innovation outputs and prevailing cognitive or normative expectations (Strang and Meyer, 1993; Suddaby et al., 2017).

However, in the context of gen-AI, output quality is not a reliably signal about the conditions of production. Highly sophisticated creative outputs may reflect minimal human involvement, while substantial human effort and intentionality may remain invisible (Tigre Moura et al., 2023; Lee, 2022). As a result, output-based legitimacy becomes inferentially unstable. Audiences increasingly struggle to reconstruct agency and responsibility from outputs alone and must rely on alternative interpretive cues. Innovation legitimacy should be reframed as a fragile inferential achievement (Bitektine and Haack, 2015; Haack et al., 2021). Legitimacy judgments emerge as sensemaking processes through which individuals attempt to resolve uncertainty about intention, effort, and moral appropriateness when conventional inferential cues are disrupted (Grimmelikhuijsen and Meijer, 2022). In AI-mediated creativity, this disruption is structurally embedded in the technology itself, due to the radical decoupling between outputs and human agency (Mayer et al., 2025; Mills and Sætra, 2025).

By conceptualizing legitimacy as an inferential process activated under conditions of opacity, this study extends prior legitimacy research into a domain where ambiguity is persistent and technologically induced. Gen-AI thus constitutes an extreme case that renders visible the micro-level processes through which legitimacy is formed, challenged, and partially reconstructed in contemporary innovation systems (Bitektine and Haack, 2015; Massi et al., 2025).

A central implication of the findings is that innovation diffusion in AI-mediated contexts becomes governance-dependent. Since creative outputs do not provide sufficient information to assess agency and responsibility, diffusion hinges on how innovation processes are organized, disclosed, and framed. Governance practices, such as transparency regarding AI involvement, the timing of disclosure, and signals of human oversight, emerge as critical interpretive infrastructures that shape whether innovations are perceived as legitimate and worthy of acceptance (Busuioc, 2021; Buhmann and Fieseler, 2023).

This insight speaks directly to ongoing debates on innovation diffusion under uncertainty (Glikson and Woolley, 2020; Martin and Waldman, 2023). The findings suggest that diffusion barriers in AI-driven innovation are interpretive and moral. Innovations may perform effectively while failing to diffuse because audiences cannot plausibly infer that they are produced in alignment with shared norms and expectations (Grimmelikhuijsen and Meijer, 2022; König and Wenzelburger, 2021). Under these conditions, governance becomes a precondition for diffusion, enabling audiences to make sense of opaque production processes and to attribute responsibility and intentionality where outputs alone are insufficient (Bitektine and Haack, 2015; Haack et al., 2021). This moves innovation legitimacy away from outcome-centered models and toward a processual understanding that is better suited to AI-mediated innovation.

6.2. Why some governance mechanisms work and others fail

The findings further reveal that governance mechanisms are asymmetrically effective. Transparency, often treated as a neutral or universally beneficial intervention in research on AI accountability and governance (Ananny and Crawford, 2018; Heimstädt and Dobusch, 2020) depends critically on timing and interpretive sequencing, because it structures sensemaking either prospectively or retrospectively.

When AI involvement is disclosed ex-ante, transparency functions as an interpretive frame that structures sensemaking from the outset. Under these conditions, audiences are less likely to form erroneous inferences about deception or effort, and legitimacy judgments are partially stabilized despite the opacity of the underlying technology (Bernstein, 2012; Bitektine and Haack, 2015). By contrast, when disclosure occurs ex-post, transparency triggers retrospective reinterpretation. In such cases, governance operates as symbolic repair, with limited capacity to restore legitimacy once negative inferences have been activated (Daly et al., 2025). Notably, this asymmetry is outcome-specific: disclosure timing significantly shapes attributions of human effort but does not affect perceived deception. This pattern suggests that deception operates as an immediate moral response to structural opacity, activated by the absence of visible human agency regardless of when governance information is provided, whereas effort attributions are more sensitive to the interpretive frame that transparency timing affords. Timing thus governs the cognitive reconstruction of agency, but not the moral judgment of communicative integrity.

Likewise, the presence of deepfake-related cues exerts a consistently negative influence across inferential dimensions. These cues activate heightened moral and epistemic concerns, amplifying perceptions of deception and undermining attributions of human effort and authenticity (Vaccari and Chadwick, 2020; De Ruiter, 2021). Unlike transparency timing, deepfake cues function as strong signals of potential manipulation that governance mechanisms struggle to counterbalance. Collectively, we can argue that governance does not guarantee legitimacy but operates as a contingent mechanism whose effectiveness depends on how it interacts with inferential processes and contextual features of the evaluative environment (Busuioc, 2021; Park, 2026).

6.3. Microfoundations of legitimacy breakdown and reconstruction

By unpacking perceived deception, human effort, and authenticity, this study exposes the microfoundations through which legitimacy breaks down and is selectively reconstructed in AI-mediated creativity (Bitektine and Haack, 2015; Haack et al., 2021). Legitimacy does not collapse uniformly under opacity; instead, it degrades through specific inferential pathways.

Specifically, perceived deception reflects moral evaluations of transparency and intent and directly undermines evaluations of message transmission, consistent with prior work on deception and trust in mediated communication (Darke and Ritchie, 2007; Ananny and Crawford, 2018). Perceived authenticity shapes evaluations of the producing organization, signaling whether creative processes are viewed as sincere and normatively appropriate (Beverland et al., 2008; Morhart et al., 2015). Perceived human effort and authenticity jointly inform creativity judgments, indicating that creativity itself emerges downstream from prior inferential assessments (Runco and Jaeger, 2012; Magni et al., 2024).

These findings highlight the sequential nature of legitimacy formation. Audiences first interpret cues related to agency, effort, and integrity before synthesizing them into higher-order evaluations of creativity and behavioral intentions (Im et al., 2015; Chu et al., 2024). Creativity,

therefore, becomes an emergent outcome of inferential sensemaking under conditions of opacity. Individual-level orientations further influence these processes. Skepticism, psychological reactance, trust in technology, and AI familiarity shape how audiences interpret ambiguous signals, reinforcing the idea that legitimacy judgments are socially and cognitively situated (Friestad and Wright, 1994; Glikson and Woolley, 2020). Of note, the positive association between AI familiarity and perceived deception, contrary to the hypothesized direction, is theoretically interpretable as a form of informed skepticism: individuals with greater exposure to generative AI systems may be more attuned to the opacity of algorithmic production processes, and therefore more sensitive to the normative violations that AI-generated content can entail. Familiarity may heighten awareness of the inferential gaps that gen-AI introduces, consistent with accounts of technology-specific disillusionment among expert users (Glikson and Woolley, 2020).

6.4. Theoretical implications

The reframing of legitimacy as governance-dependent (Section 6.1), the conditional effectiveness of governance mechanisms (Section 6.2), and the microfoundational pathways of legitimacy breakdown and reconstruction (Section 6.3) converge into a single theoretical account. This study contributes to the literature by identifying the conditions under which performance-centered models of innovation legitimacy break down and specifying the inferential processes through which legitimacy is partially reconstructed. The theoretical reframing proposed here is deliberately circumscribed: it does not challenge legitimacy theory broadly but identifies AI-induced technological opacity as a boundary condition under which output-based legitimacy evaluation becomes inferentially unstable and governance-dependent sensemaking becomes the primary mechanism through which audiences reconstruct normative appropriateness. Individual-level dispositions, such as skepticism, psychological reactance, trust in technology, and AI familiarity, act as a distinct set of antecedents that further shape how this reconstruction unfolds across audiences (see Table 10). This contributes a more precise microfoundational account of legitimacy formation in AI-mediated innovation contexts (Bitektine and Haack, 2015; Haack et al., 2021).

Table 10
Revised inferential model of innovation legitimacy under AI-mediated creativity.

Inferential Stage	Triggering Conditions	Dominant Inferential Shift	Consequence for Innovation Legitimacy
Breakdown of output-based cues	AI-generated (vs. AI-assisted) creative production	Outputs no longer signal human effort or agency	Output-based legitimacy weakens due to inferential opacity
Governance-dependent sensemaking	Timing of AI disclosure (ex-ante vs. ex-post)	Legitimacy judgments depend on whether sensemaking is framed prospectively or retrospectively	Governance operates as interpretive infrastructure rather than legitimacy repair
Heightened moral uncertainty	Presence of deepfake-related cues	Increased suspicion of deception and manipulation	Legitimacy becomes fragile and difficult to reconstruct
Inferential reconstruction of meaning	Perceived human effort and authenticity	Creativity is inferred from process cues rather than output novelty	Legitimacy partially stabilizes through governance-aligned interpretations
Translation into evaluative outcomes	Perceived creativity	Positive behavioral intentions emerge downstream from inferential judgments	Diffusion depends on inferentially sustained legitimacy
Individual-level dispositional antecedents	Skepticism, reactance, trust in technology, AI familiarity	Heterogeneous interpretation of governance signals	Legitimacy judgments remain contingent and audience-specific

Authors' elaboration.

The findings reposition governance from a compliance-oriented function to a core mechanism of innovation diffusion. Governance structures enable interpretation and acceptance when technologies obscure traditional cues of responsibility and intention (Busuioc, 2021; Buhmann and Fieseler, 2023). This reframing is aligned with broader discussions on responsible innovation and AI governance (Floridi et al., 2018; Floridi, 2024).

The study also conceptualizes gen-AI as a legitimacy-disrupting general-purpose technology. Its capacity to decouple outputs from human agency introduces systemic challenges for how innovation is evaluated, governed, and diffused across sectors (Mayer et al., 2025; Mills and Sætra, 2025). Addressing these challenges requires theoretical models that integrate micro-level sensemaking with macro-level governance arrangements.

To consolidate the theoretical implications of the study, Table 10 presents a revised inferential model of innovation legitimacy under AI-mediated creativity. Building on prior work on legitimacy as an inferential and processual construct (Bitektine and Haack, 2015; Haack et al., 2021) and on governance under algorithmic opacity (Ananny and Crawford, 2018; Busuioc, 2021), the table articulates how the inferential basis of legitimacy judgments shifts from output-based evaluation toward governance-dependent sensemaking through a sequence of inferential stages.

6.5. Practical implications for governing AI-mediated innovation

The findings offer practical implications for organizations, policymakers, and designers engaged in the development and deployment of AI-mediated creative innovation. The study highlights conditional governance choices that shape how legitimacy is inferred under conditions of technological opacity.

First, the results suggest that disclosing AI involvement does not automatically restore trust or legitimacy. Instead, the timing and framing of disclosure are critical design choices. Ex-ante disclosure allows audiences to interpret creative content within an appropriate interpretive frame, whereas ex-post disclosure risks undermining perceptions of human effort and intentionality. Organizations deploying AI-mediated creativity should therefore consider transparency as part of process design.

Second, the findings indicate that legitimacy is also developed based on how AI is positioned within the creative process. Presenting AI as the primary creative agent amplifies perceptions of deception and reduces perceived human effort, even when output quality is high. By contrast, framing AI as a supporting tool helps preserve attributions of human agency and responsibility. For practitioners, this implies that organizational narratives about AI use, more than being communicative choices, are mechanisms able to shape legitimacy judgements.

Third, the consistent effects of deepfake-related cues highlight the importance of managing synthetic manipulation signals in AI-mediated communication. Deepfake cues activate moral and epistemic concerns that governance mechanisms struggle to counteract. This suggests that verification markers, contextual explanations, and safeguards against misleading resemblance should be embedded into the design of AI-generated content. In highly ambiguous contexts, governance cannot fully restore legitimacy, it can just mitigate legitimacy loss at its best.

Ultimately, the study underscores that legitimacy risks in AI-mediated creativity are not uniform: individual differences in skepticism, reactance, and trust in technology systematically shape how governance signals are interpreted. One-size-fits-all disclosure regimes are therefore unlikely to succeed; organizations and regulators should design accountability mechanisms that account for audience

heterogeneity, particularly in high-stakes or highly visible creative domains.

These insights translate into three concrete governance recommendations. First, organizations deploying AI in creative production should establish ex-ante disclosure protocols as a standard practice, embedding transparency into content production workflows. Second, when framing AI involvement, organizations should systematically emphasize human oversight and editorial control, even when AI generates the primary output, to preserve attributions of human agency and authenticity. Third, in contexts where deepfake-like synthetic elements are present, organizations should proactively deploy verification markers and contextual explanations as part of content design, recognizing that governance mechanisms alone are insufficient to fully counteract the moral uncertainty activated by synthetic manipulation cues.

7. Conclusions

This study examined how legitimacy judgments are formed when creative outputs fail to provide reliable information about human agency, effort, and responsibility. Focusing on AI-mediated creativity under conditions of technological opacity and deepfake uncertainty, the study advances a central argument: innovation legitimacy increasingly shifts from output-based evaluation to governance-dependent inferential processes.

By conceptualizing legitimacy as an inferential judgment, the study contributes to innovation research in three ways. First, it demonstrates the limits of performance-centered models of legitimacy when gen-AI decouples output quality from human agency. Second, it shows that governance mechanisms, such as transparency timing and the framing of AI's role, operate asymmetrically by shaping how audiences interpret agency, effort, and authenticity. Third, it reveals the microfoundations through which legitimacy is selectively weakened and partially reconstructed, highlighting the sequential role of deception, human effort, authenticity, and creativity in shaping evaluative and behavioral outcomes.

Therefore, the diffusion and acceptance of AI-driven innovation depend less on what technologies produce and more on how their production processes are governed, communicated, and interpreted. In this sense, gen-AI emerges as a powerful creative technology, but also as a legitimacy-disrupting innovation that challenges established assumptions about evaluation, responsibility, and trust in innovation systems.

8. Limitations and future research

This research has limitations that open important avenues for future investigation. First, the study focuses on a specific set of creative stimuli and experimental manipulations. While this design allows for strong internal validity and precise identification of inferential mechanisms, future research could extend the framework to other innovation domains characterized by algorithmic opacity, such as healthcare, finance, public sector decision-making, or platform governance. Examining whether similar inferential dynamics emerge across domains would strengthen the generalizability of the proposed model.

Second, the study adopts a cross-sectional experimental design that captures legitimacy judgments at a single point in time. Future research could explore how inferential judgments evolve longitudinally as audiences gain repeated exposure to AI-mediated creativity or as governance practices become institutionalized. Such work could shed light on whether governance-dependent legitimacy stabilizes over time or remains inherently fragile.

Third, the effects of deepfake-related cues are treated in this study as uniformly negative across conditions and individuals. However, audience responses to synthetic media may be more heterogeneous than this framing suggests. Individuals with higher familiarity with deepfake technology, greater exposure to synthetic media, or different normative orientations toward digital manipulation may interpret deepfake cues differently, potentially attenuating or reversing the negative inferential effects observed here. Future research should examine whether and how individual differences in deepfake literacy and prior exposure moderate the effects of synthetic manipulation cues on legitimacy judgments.

Fourth, while this study focuses on audience-side evaluations, future research could integrate producer-side perspectives to examine how organizations strategically design governance mechanisms in response to legitimacy challenges. Investigating the co-evolution of governance practices and audience expectations would provide a more dynamic account of legitimacy construction in AI-driven innovation.

A further boundary condition concerns the cultural and attitudinal context of legitimacy judgments. The sample, while cross-national, is predominantly drawn from Italy, the United Kingdom, and the Philippines, contexts that may differ systematically in their normative orientations toward AI, institutional trust, and expectations of transparency in organizational communication. Cultural variation in the acceptance of AI-mediated creativity and in the moral framing of deception may moderate the inferential processes identified in this study. Similarly, prior attitudes toward AI and familiarity with deepfakes are likely to shape how audiences interpret governance signals independently of the dispositional characteristics examined in this study. Future research should explicitly examine how cultural context, prior AI attitudes, and normative orientations toward technology moderate the inferential mechanisms identified here, and how legitimacy judgments vary across social groups and institutional environments in globally diverse settings.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Domitilla Magni: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Project administration, Methodology, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Giuseppe Lanfranchi:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Project administration, Investigation, Conceptualization. **Maria Esmeralda Palaganas:** Writing – review & editing, Investigation.

Declaration of competing interests

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Appendix A. Supplementary data

Supplementary data to this article can be found online at https://doi.org/10.1016/j.technovation.2026.103693.

Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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